

BATTLE FOR JUSTICE

Rizwanur Rahman's death under mysterious circumstances has led to widespread protests against the police's inefficiency in a state notorious for inconclusive investigations and elusive justice



■ By Swagata Sen

I'm an honest and sincere citizen of India and have done everything respecting the Constitution. As adults, we have married according to the law of the land. Please help me get in touch with my wife." This was the last letter that Rizwanur Rahman wrote. Dated September 19, the letter was addressed to the Association for Protection of Democratic Rights. Two days later, Rahman's body was found lying on railway tracks in Kolkata. In his wallet was some loose change and a picture of a girl—his wife Priyanka, who was to be "returned" to him the week before.

As the 100-day-long candlelight vigil at Rahman's alma mater, St Xavier's College, Kolkata, enters its

third week, pandal-hoppers take a silent moment to stop, light a candle, and sign a banner of protest amid puja festivities. Already, 30,000 signatures have been etched. "Some people are more powerful dead than when alive," says one of the posters. No loud protests, just the strength of silence.

On October 16, the Calcutta High Court issued an interim order and finally handed over the Rahman case from the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) to the CBI, acting on a plea by his mother Kishwar Jahan for an independent enquiry into her son's unexplained death. The agency is to submit its report in two months. For a state Government grappling with its reputation, a third CBI inquiry in a year (after Nandigram and the Tapasi Malik murder in Singur) is not good news.

THE RIGHT CAUSE: Candlelight vigil for Rahman at St Xavier's

The state police is already under a cloud. Prasun Mukherjee has been removed from his post of Commissioner and Gautam Mohan Chakraborty, Additional CP, has been appointed the new Commissioner. Public emotion is running high with a flurry of protests, vigils, sms and web signature campaigns. Rahman, a middle-class graphic design teacher at a multimedia institute, is now the nation's tragic hero, powerful enough to bring down the state machinery.

When Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya finally visited Rahman's house last week, his car was pounded with fists by the locals. A bumbling government found itself promising to suspend the accused policemen, and